



A submarine embarks on a mission in the Atlantic. German U-boats terrorized the seas, attacking both naval and merchant shipping at will.



A German airship taking off from its base for a bombing raid on London.

AT THE START OF 1915, THE GREAT POWERS OF EUROPE remained locked in a war for which they had been unprepared. The fighting had exhausted munition supplies, so to continue the war the

On the **Western Front**, the **stalemate continued** along a double line of trenches that stretched from the Channel to the Swiss border. Generals assumed that sufficient numbers

of men and shells hurled against these defenses would achieve a breakthrough, but they were wrong.

The British attempted their first offensive of the trench war at **Neuve Chapelle** in March, with Indian troops leading the assault and the Canadian Expeditionary Force fighting for the first time. They

gained a mere 1.2 miles (2km) of ground for 11,000 casualties. The Germans had a similar experience attacking at **Ypres** in April, and

the French suffered in repeated offensives throughout the year. Mass offensives led only to mass casualties—**over 300,000 British and French losses** in the autumn Champagne-Loos offensive.

On the Eastern Front, the fighting was far more mobile, and the **Russians were forced to retreat** from Poland and Lithuania.

In an attempt to break the deadlock on the Western Front, the Germans **used poison gas for the first time** at Ypres in April, releasing lethal chlorine to drift across to the Allied trenches. The first victims were French colonial troops on April 22, followed two days later by soldiers of the First Canadian Division. But German troops failed to take advantage of the initial impact of the gas; Allied soldiers quickly discovered means of protection, and the Allies also adopted gas as a weapon against the Germans.



FRENCH CARVED CLUB

BRITISH SPIKED CLUB

GERMAN METAL ROD

Savage attacks
Soldiers raiding enemy trenches often carried primitive weapons for close-quarters combat. As well as clubs like these, they used trench knives, knuckle dusters, and even spades in savage melees.



Chemical warfare

Before the advent of the gas mask, troops, such as these French soldiers, protected themselves from a gas attack in any way they could.

combatants had to **vastly expand their armaments industries**. Governments became aware that the war would be won, or lost, as much in the factories as on the front line. Britain set up a new Ministry of Munitions, and in Russia the czarist government set up a special War Industries Committee. The French, meanwhile, had to recall conscripts from the trenches to work in factories, their production problems accentuated by the German occupation of industrial areas of northeast France.

WOMEN AT WAR

A shortage of manpower meant that women were recruited into a range of jobs traditionally reserved for men. By 1918, around a third of the 1.7 million workers in French munitions factories were women, and they constituted over half of the total German industrial workforce. Women also replaced men as agricultural laborers, for example in the British Women's Land Army.



On April 26, **Italy signed the Treaty of London**, committing it to enter the war on the side of Britain and France. Before the war, Italy had been an ally of Germany and Austria-Hungary, so this was a diplomatic coup for the Western Allies. Italy duly declared war on Austria on May 23, and the fighting on the **Italo-Austrian Front** quickly descended into the same static stalemate as on the Western Front.

While stalemate persisted on the ground, **war in the air developed on a substantial scale**. Slow-moving aircraft flew over enemy trenches taking reconnaissance photographs and engaged in small-scale bombing missions, while nimbler fighter aircraft intercepted them.

Away from the battlefield, Germany's Zeppelin and Schütte-Lanze airships embarked on the **world's first long-range bombing campaign**, with Britain as their main target. German Navy airship commander Captain Peter Strasser believed that Britain could be "overcome by means of

airships...through increasingly extensive destruction of cities, factory complexes, dockyards...." This was, in reality, far beyond the airships' capacity, but from May 31 onward **night raids** on London and other major cities still managed to cause many civilian casualties and forced Britain to divert resources from the Western Front to **home defense**.

At sea, Germany responded to an ongoing blockade of its ports by the British Royal Navy by attempting to impose its own blockade on Britain through the use of submarines. From February **German U-boats** were authorized to attack merchant shipping in British home waters without warning. On May 7, the Cunard liner **Lusitania**, bound from New York to Liverpool with almost 2,000 passengers and crew on board, was torpedoed off southern Ireland by the submarine **U-20**. More than 1,200 people were drowned, including 128 Americans citizens. The attack provoked anti-German riots in British cities and a hostile response in the US. After the

